

Chapter 53-2

The sunset was an extremely rapid process. Soon the streetlights came on, illuminating the world in an instant.

Fear flashed through Qi Jiao's heart as she used all her strength to push Cheng Ran away. "I really have to go."

Having already been aroused, Cheng Ran's eyes flashed with impatience, but looking at Qi Jiao's delicate face, she quickly restrained her aggression.

She reached out to wipe near Qi Jiao's mouth, her thumb gently caressing the tender skin, taking away a trace of moisture, then pulled out a wet tissue to gently clean her fingers.

Cheng Ran also helped Qi Jiao tidy up her scattered hair, pulling up the loose coat and even zipping it up.

She patted her on the head. "Be good, just say it's a friend's."

Qi Jiao, weakened by her teasing, bit her lip and immediately turned to run away.

Cheng Ran watched her retreating figure, taking a cigarette from her pocket, holding it between her fingers and lighting it.

The crimson glow scattered in the night, and the fire suppressed in her heart finally dissipated somewhat.

However, hadn't she been playing with this woman for quite a while now?

As she was thinking, her phone rang.

She glanced at the screen and answered, her voice carrying unsatisfied hoarseness and impatience. "What is it?"

"A girl who just came back." The other party sounded excited. "Sister Ran¹, saved you the youngest one."

"Is she of age?" Cheng Ran asked, taking a drag of her cigarette.

The other party laughed. "Of course she is. She's the same type as the one you've been liking recently, very fresh and beautiful."

Cheng Ran looked in the direction where Qi Jiao had left, a thought of refusal flashing through her mind, but the other party laughed. "Sister Ran? Settling down?"

Cheng Ran extinguished the half-smoked cigarette, lightly exhaling a puff of smoke as that suppressed desire appeared again. Her voice was indifferent as she said, "Send her to the upstairs room, make her wash clean."

"Don't worry." The other party said, "For Sister Ran to play with, how could she not be clean? She's still a virgin too."

Cheng Ran said nothing and hung up.

On the other side, Qi Jiao looked at her phone—it was already 18:58.

Thinking of the situation she might face when she got home, she quickened her pace, but having been bullied too harshly by Cheng Ran just now, she had no strength left.

She ran frantically for a few steps, her blue long dress flying in the night.

Running until she was gasping for breath, she finally reached the front gate at 59 seconds. Before she could celebrate, she looked up and saw the woman wearing a water-green qipao².

Yang Jiani stood at the doorway, dim yellow light falling on her.

Though it was clearly early autumn, she was dressed lightly, holding a Republic-era style fan in her hand.

Her gaze fell upon Qi Jiao, who felt a bone-chilling coldness, her footsteps seeming nailed to the spot.

Yang Jiani glanced in the direction from which Qi Jiao had just run, speaking unhurriedly. "Who was that person?"

Qi Jiao's heart tightened, swallowing hard as she fearfully called out, "Mom."

"Whose coat are you wearing again?" Yang Jiani calmly looked her over, her gaze falling on the black coat she was wearing. Frightened, Qi Jiao shivered and immediately began taking off the coat.

But her fingers were trembling, and while pulling the zipper, she accidentally caught her fingertip flesh in it.

The pain made her gasp.

Her finger was bleeding, but she dared not delay even slightly, immediately taking off the coat and throwing it on the ground.

She nervously answered, "A... a friend's."

Yang Jiani closed the fan in her hand, smiling slightly. "Qi Jiao, are you lying to me?"

Qi Jiao shook her head. "No..."

But this "no" was said very weakly.

"Qi Jiao, you know what punishment liars receive, don't you?" Yang Jiani leaned against the wall, appearing entirely languid, but Qi Jiao knew that this version of her was the most terrifying.

Qi Jiao closed her eyes, a tear falling. "I'm sorry."

"Who wants to hear your apology?" Yang Jiani laughed. "You're in love? With whom?"

Qi Jiao's hand hanging at her side clenched into a fist, nervously answering, "It's... someone I... met... on the road before."

"Which road?" Yang Jiani asked. "When did this happen?"

Qi Jiao: "..."

She stammered out the story of meeting Cheng Ran.

But Yang Jiani extracted key information from her words, raising an eyebrow slightly. "Chengqiang Road³? That's the road to Angel Orphanage. Who were you thinking of?"

Qi Jiao shrank her shoulders. "No, the kindergarten organized a staff activity, we went to Loving Care Nursing Home."

"So what did you remember there?" Yang Jiani looked at her, her voice suddenly becoming mournful. "Jiao Jiao."

Indescribable fear rose from the bottom of her heart.

Even though she had been Qi Jiao for many years, she still couldn't get used to it.

Yang Jiani straightened up, opening the villa's front door. "Come in."

Qi Jiao dragged her two stiff legs forward, knowing tonight was destined to be sleepless.

As Yang Jiani led her into the villa, she said gently, "Lying, falling in love, and letting someone touch your body—Qi Jiao, you know what you should do, don't you?"

Though her voice was gentle, Qi Jiao felt like she was hearing a vengeful ghost demanding her life.

She closed her eyes and answered despairingly, "I know."

Footnotes:

1. **Sister Ran:** A respectful way to address an older woman or someone in a position of authority, showing deference in Chinese culture.
2. **Qipao:** A traditional Chinese dress, also known as cheongsam, characterized by a high collar and fitted silhouette.
3. **Chengqiang Road:** A street name. Chinese addresses often use directional or descriptive terms; "cheng" (城) means city/wall and "qiang" (墙) means wall.